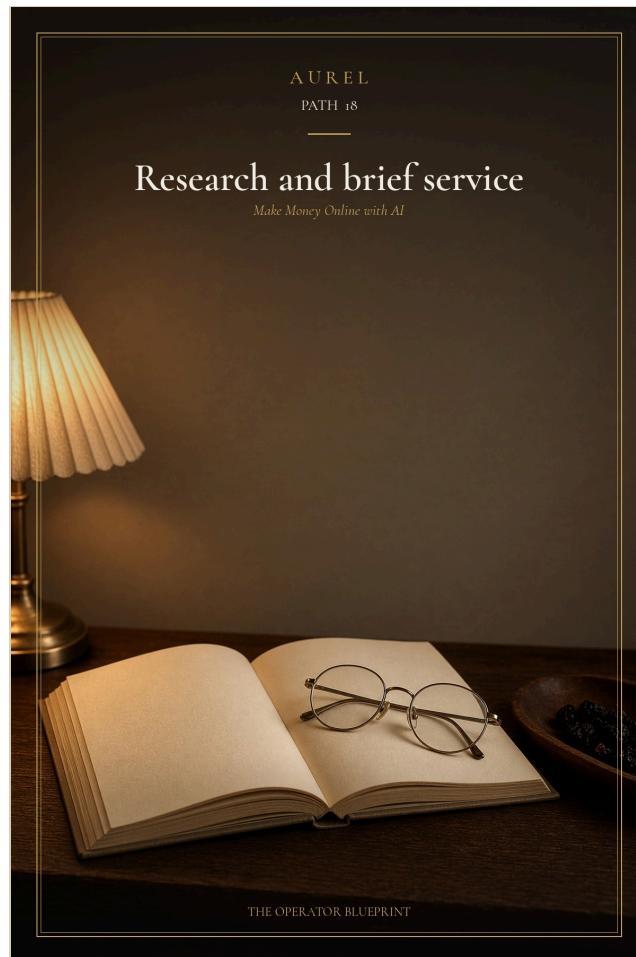




PATH 18

Research and brief service

A messy question in. A two-page brief out. You verify what the model cannot know.

39 minute read · 8,656 words

Who this is for

You can turn a pile of tabs into a decision someone can use this week. You already know which sources in your niche lie.

Time to first

3–10 days

Tools

First sale

One paid brief delivered on time to a person who is not you.

Cash window

\$150–\$600 per brief

Leave this alone

Docs, a five-field order form, Stripe Payment Link, a sources policy, dated screenshots.

Claiming the model knows everything. Publishing unreviewed facts. Turning a \$300 brief into an unpaid project.

What this actually is

A research brief is a paid decision file. A messy question comes in. Two pages go out in 48 hours. The pages say what you found, what you verified, what is still unknown, and the next step a human can take this week. One revision is included. The clock is part of the product.

Anyone can paste a question into a model. What they get back is a confident first draft with an unknown number of invented citations. You sell the check. You are not a search engine with a nicer font. You are the person who will write "I could not verify this" in plain type, then still recommend a next step that does not depend on a fake number.

The product is judgment. The model is a junior researcher who works fast and lies when bored. You keep the job of saying which numbers can stand in a meeting. If you cannot say that out loud, you are selling a paste, and a paste does not hold a \$300 price.

What a brief is not

It is not a white paper. It is not a twelve-page literature review. It is not "I will go deep on your whole market." Executives do not read twelve pages. Operators do not need a seminar. They need a decision, on a date, with the holes labeled.

It is not consulting by the hour. It is not sitting in their Slack. It is not interviews you did not quote in the scope. It is not building the thing you recommended. The moment you start implementing, you have left this product and entered a project you forgot to price.

It is not a newsletter issue with their name swapped in. The paid file is private, dated, and written for one decision.

Why this works now

Models made first drafts cheap and citations untrustworthy at the same time. The people who would have spent a Saturday on twenty tabs now spend twenty minutes on a chat window, then still do not know which sentence they can repeat to a partner. That gap is the brief.

The gap is larger in niches where a wrong number has a cost: a clinic changing software, a contractor picking a supplier, a shop choosing a POS. Those buyers already pay for speed. They will pay more for a file they can forward without you on the call.

You do not need a following. You need three people who already ask you "what should I do about X?" and a template that forces a recommendation. The market is not "AI research." The market is one named decision with a date on it.

Three anti-patterns

The first anti-pattern is the unreviewed dump. You paste the model output, add a cover, and call it verified. That is how this path dies in public. One hallucinated citation in a file with your name on it is enough.

The second is the endless research project. You take a week because you want to be thorough. Thorough without a clock is a hobby. The 48-hour box is what makes the file a product instead of a rabbit hole.

The third is scope creep into doing the work. They ask you to "just hop on and help implement." You say yes because the brief felt small. A \$300 file becomes a \$3,000 job you did at \$300. The brief recommends. It does not build.

The deal you keep

You keep a short clock, a short file, and a spine in the "do not know" section. You keep a sources policy written before the first paid job. You keep one revision that means clarify or correct, not "now also write the strategy deck." You keep the right to recommend a next step that is not you. That deal is the business. Everything else is a different path with a different number.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if people already ask you "what should I do about X?" and you already open twenty tabs before you answer. You can tell a primary source from a blog that copied a blog. You can say "I do not know" without feeling like you failed. You can write two tight pages in a working day after the sweep.

You do not need a research degree. You need a niche where you already know the landscape: a trade, a software category, a local market, a regulation you have had to live with. The niche is what makes verification fast.

This fits you if

You have a niche where you already know which publications, filings, vendors, and forums are worth opening.

You can write two tight pages in a working day after the sweep, without padding.

You will check the citations. Not some of them. The ones you present as fact.

You can name three people who have asked you for this kind of help in the last year.

You would rather recommend a next step than own the whole project.

Skip this path if

Skip it if you want to publish unreviewed model output under your name. Skip it if you freeze when a number cannot be confirmed. Skip it if you would rather build the whole project than recommend a next step. Scope creep into doing the work is how a \$300 brief becomes a \$3,000 job you forgot to price.

Skip it if you cannot yet name three people who already ask you for this kind of help. Do a productized service or a playbook in a job you know, then offer briefs to the same people. Skip it if you need cash tomorrow morning. Three to ten days is honest.

The honest middle

If you have done this kind of sweep twice for free, in email threads you never billed, this is the product hiding in those threads. Capture the last one as a two-page sample with fake names.

You are not waiting to become an analyst. You are waiting to put a clock and a price on work you already do badly for free.

If you have only done it once, do the next one as a paid \$150 case with a written sources policy. One file. On time. Then lock the fee.

Skills and time

You need a working day you can protect twice a week. The sweep and the write are four to eight hours inside a 48-hour window. You also need twenty minutes to send three offers, and the nerve to start the clock only when intake and payment are both in.

Writing skill here is short sentences and a recommendation that is a verb plus an object plus a time. If your natural mode is a twelve-page memo, this path will feel like cutting. That cut is the product.

Two-minute self-test

Answer these out loud. If you cannot, this is not your path this month.

Name one niche where you already know the sources that lie.

Name three people who have asked you "what should I do about X?" in the last year.

Name one decision those people actually have to make in the next 30 days.

Say, in one breath, what you will not do as part of a \$300 brief.

Say what you will write when a key number cannot be confirmed.

If all five have answers, write the template today. If two are blank, pick a different path or go get the missing reps before you charge.

The offer, named in one sentence

Fill this and put it on the order form: "48-hour brief for [named person] on [named decision].

Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$[price]. One revision included."

That is the whole offer. If you cannot fit it on a sticky note, you are selling a retainer. The named person and the named decision are what keep you out of "I research anything." The clock, the page count, and the revision rule are what keep you out of unpaid follow-up.

Five sentences you can copy

48-hour brief for independent clinic owners deciding whether to switch schedulers. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. One revision included.

48-hour brief for one-person HVAC shops picking a dispatch tool before the heating season. Two pages. Verified, unknown, next step. \$300. One revision.

48-hour brief for a shop owner choosing a POS this quarter. Two pages. What I opened, what I could not confirm, what to do this week. \$300.

48-hour brief for a solo accountant deciding whether to move a client book onto a new practice platform. Two pages. Sources checked. \$450 if you send the current contract clause.

48-hour brief for a contractor comparing two material suppliers on lead time and published pricing, not on a sales call. Two pages. \$300.

Write yours with a person you can text. Do not write "busy professionals" or "leaders." Those are not buyers. A clinic owner with two front-desk people giving notice is a buyer.

What they get

Intake: the decision they must make, the deadline, what they already tried.

A sweep with a model, used as a map, never sent.

Your verification pass against sources you named in advance.

Two pages delivered in 48 hours from a complete intake, not from the first vague email.

A recommended next step that is a verb, an object, and a time.

A "do not know" section that is specific.

One revision window of 48 hours after delivery. Revision means clarify or correct, not a second question.

What they do not get

Building the thing. Sitting in their Slack. Monitoring a topic for a month. Interviews you did not quote in the scope. A deck. A workshop. A second topic folded into the first file. Unlimited email until they "feel ready." If they need those, that is a different package with a different number.

They also do not get your working dump, your prompt, or a promise that the recommendation will make them money. They get a defensible file on a date.

Packaging

One product. One price on the form. Payment before the clock. 48 hours starts when intake is complete and the payment is in, whichever is later. Delivery is a PDF or Doc they own, filename with topic and date.

Do not bundle four briefs for the price of three in month one. Do not add a "strategy call" that becomes the whole job. If you want a 20-minute walkthrough after delivery, write it as an extra at \$75 or include it once, in writing. Do not let a call replace the file.

A rush under 24 hours is a different package: same two pages, add 50 percent, only if you actually have the hours. A second topic is a second brief.

What done looks like

Done is a two-page file the buyer can forward without you on the call. It has a recommended next step that a human could take this week. It has a "do not know" section that is specific, not theatrical. Sources that are stated as fact have been opened by you. The clock was kept. The revision window is stated in the delivery email. Then the job is closed unless they buy another brief.

Done is not "I sent a thoughtful email." Done is a file they own, in their inbox, inside 48 hours of a complete intake, with a name they can find in six months.

The fairness test

Hand the brief to someone who does not know the buyer. In three minutes they should be able to say: the decision, the recommendation, the biggest uncertainty. If they cannot, you wrote an

essay. If they can, the buyer can forward page one to a partner without a decoder.

Fairness also means the price and the clock matched what they bought. A 48-hour brief delivered on day four is not done. It is a late file plus an apology. A two-page product padded to seven pages is not "more value." It is a failure of the product you sold.

Technical done

PDF or Doc they own, in their inbox, inside 48 hours of a complete intake.

Filename with the topic and the date, not "brief_final_v3."

Six headings present: decision, found, verified, do not know, next step, one thing I would not do.

Every fact in the verified section has a source you opened, with enough to reopen it: title, publisher, date, URL.

Recommendation is a verb plus an object plus a time.

One revision if they ask inside the window. Then closed.

Not done yet

You started on a voice note and the decision is still mush.

A number in the verified section lives only in a model dump.

"Do not know" is empty, or it says "more research needed" with no object.

The next step is "consider exploring options."

You are waiting to "add a few more sources" past the clock.

They asked a second question and you started writing it into the same file for free.

You have not restated the revision window in the delivery email.

The file is still in your drafts because you want it to feel smarter.

If any of those are true, you do not invoice the feeling. You finish the file or you stop the clock in writing and refund. There is no third option called "almost."

Pricing

The cash window is \$150–\$600 per brief. Robin sells at \$300. That is the number to copy until you have proof you are slow or uniquely sourced. Put the number on the form. Do not hide it behind "let us hop on a call."

Ranges

\$150 if this is your first paid brief, the topic is one you already know, and you need a case. Discount once. Then lock the fee.

\$300 for a standard 48-hour, two-page, one-revision brief with named sources. Default. This is Robin. This is you.

\$450–\$600 if they need you to include a small set of primary documents they provide (filings, a competitor's pricing page, a contract clause) and the decision is time-sensitive inside their week. Still two pages. Still 48 hours. The extra money is the extra verification, not extra paper.

Do not charge hourly. A slow reader should not earn more than a fast one for the same two pages. Do not charge \$50. That price buys a paste, and they will treat it like one. Do not charge \$2,000 for two pages in month one. You have no cases and you will freeze.

When to raise

After three on-time briefs at the current fee, if you are turning work away or the decisions got heavier. Raise \$300 to \$450, or \$450 to \$600. Raise because the calendar is full or the verification is harder, not because a compliment felt good. If you discounted the first to \$150, the second is \$300. No story.

Refunds in one sentence

If the file is late without a written clock change, or a stated fact was not opened at the source, you refund. You do not refund because they disliked the recommendation.

Never charge for these

Never charge for "I'll look at it and we can see." That is the brief. Never charge a discovery fee that becomes a free brief. Never charge for a second topic inside the first file. Never charge a monthly "research retainer" until five briefs have landed on time. Never charge to sit in Slack. Never charge \$49 so you can be sloppy.

Worked dollars

Robin's first paid brief: \$300 in, about five hours of real work inside a 48-hour clock, two of them verification. The buyer was not buying hours. They were buying a decision file before October 1. Three \$300 briefs in a month is \$900 around a job. Five at \$300 is \$1,500. Worked dollars go up when you stop discounting and stop turning briefs into projects.

The first 72 hours

You do not need a website. You need a template, a fee, and three people who already ask you what to do. The 72 hours are for those three things, not for a brand.

Day 1 morning: the brief template

Open a two-page Doc with locked headings:

Decision on the table

What I found

What I verified (with sources)

What I do not know

Recommended next step

One thing I would not do

Write a one-paragraph sources policy under the template: sites you will use, sites you will not, and the rule that an unchecked number is not a fact. If you will not use Reddit as a source, say so. If a trade journal is in, say so. If vendor marketing pages are allowed only as "vendor claims," say so. This paragraph is what you will point at when someone wants a citation you refuse.

Do not design a cover. Do not pick a logo. Headings and a policy. If the headings feel tight, good. They are supposed to.

Day 1 afternoon: the order form and the number

Five fields only: name, email, the decision they must make, the deadline, what they already tried. Price on the form. \$300. Payment before you start the clock. 48 hours starts when intake is complete and the payment is in, whichever is later. State working days if you will not run the clock over a weekend. Write it before they pay.

Use Tally or Google Form plus a Stripe Payment Link. Buy your own form from a second email if you need to see the confirmation. You do not need a proposal tool. You do not need a scheduling link that turns into a free consult.

Day 1 night: the three names

Write three names. Not a cold list. People who already lean on you. Next to each name, write the decision you think they actually have. If you cannot name a decision, you do not have an offer for that person this week. Go to bed with the three lines, not with a content calendar.

Day 2: three offers, then a sample if you need one

Send the sentence to those three. Not a newsletter. Not a launch. A message.

"I turned the way I already help you into a 48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. If you have a decision this month, I'll take one."

If nobody has a live decision, offer one discounted first seat at \$150 to get a case, to the person whose decision is closest. Deliver that one on time. Then lock the price. A late free brief teaches the wrong lesson.

If you have never written a two-pager in this shape, spend Day 2 afternoon writing a sample on a decision you already made, with fake names. You do not send it as the paid file.

Day 3: intake discipline and a closed loop

If someone said yes, collect payment, then the intake. Do not start on a voice note. Incomplete intake does not start the 48 hours. Reply with the five fields and wait.

If nobody said yes, send the same sentence to two more people from the same pile, or pick a different path on Friday. Do not rewrite the offer six times in 72 hours. Do not add a blog. The action is asks plus a template that can take a yes.

The path, step by step

Do these in order. The clock is part of the product. Skipping verification to "make the date" is how you ship fiction. Skipping the date to "verify more" is how you ship a hobby.

Write the two-page template and the sources policy. Lock the six headings so you cannot wander. Name sources you will use and sources you refuse. If you cannot name sources you refuse, you are not ready to charge for verification. The policy is one paragraph, not a legal memo.

Put \$300 on a one-page offer. Intake fields, turnaround, one revision, what is out. Payment link above the fold. Working days stated if they matter. The page is allowed to be ugly. It is not allowed to be vague. Test-buy from a second email so you know the confirmation arrives.

Ask three people who already ask you "what should I do about X?" Offer one discounted first seat if you need a sample, then never discount without a reason you can say out loud. Direct messages. The sentence is the message. If they reply with a different job, sell a different path or say no.

On a yes: collect payment, then the intake. Do not start on a voice note. Incomplete intake does not start the 48 hours. If they pay and the decision field says "help with marketing," write back: "I need the decision, the deadline, and what you already tried. Clock starts when those are in."

Sweep with a model. Prompt it for a map: claims, names, numbers, competing views. Dump that into a working doc you will not send. Ask for disagreements, not just a summary. The dump will be confident and partly wrong. Your job in this step is coverage, not truth.

Verify. Open the sources. Check the numbers. Kill anything you cannot confirm. Move the rest to "do not know" or cut it. Date the screenshots for prices and claims that might move. If a vendor page is the only home of a number, it is a vendor claim, not a fact. If a Reddit thread is the only home of a horror story, cut it.

Write two pages in your voice. Short sentences. The recommendation sits near the top, not after a tour of the landscape. You may be wrong. You may not be fuzzy. Put the decision in the first five lines so a partner who only reads page one still gets the job.

Fill "do not know" with specifics. "I could not find 2025 market share from a primary filing. Vendor blogs claim 18 percent. Treat as unverified." If the recommendation depends on an unverified number, change the recommendation.

Fill "one thing I would not do." This heading exists so you take a side. "I would not sign an annual on a sales call this week." A brief that will not say no is a summary. Summaries are free.

Deliver inside 48 hours as a file they own. Filename with topic and date. Restate the revision window in the email. Restate that a second question is a second brief. Do not attach the sweep dump.

If they revise, you clarify or correct. You do not add a second question. If they want the second question, sell brief two. If they want you to implement, quote a different path. Close the window when it closes.

After delivery, ask one thing: which sentence they used. That sentence becomes your next outbound line. If they used nothing, ask what they needed that was missing. Usually it is a clearer next step, not more pages.

After three on-time briefs, raise from \$150 (if you discounted) to \$300, or from \$300 to \$450 if demand is real and your calendar is full. Do not stay at \$150 because discounting feels kind. Raise because the calendar is full, not because a compliment felt good.

Only after five on-time briefs may you consider a monthly watch, and only as a named retainer with a named topic. Most operators should not. Stacking single briefs is cleaner.

Keep a folder of dated screenshots and a one-line log: date, buyer type, decision, fee, on time or not, sentence they used. A sheet with five rows is enough. Fill the row before you send the next ask.

Stop or split if a brief keeps turning into a project. Fix the offer sentence and the "what is out" line before you take another dollar. The path dies when you become their cheap project manager.

A worked example: Robin's \$300 brief

Robin helps independent clinic owners who keep asking whether they should buy a new scheduling tool. Robin is not a software vendor. Robin has sat through four of these decisions in two years and is tired of rewriting the same email. That email thread is the product, unpriced.

Monday: template, policy, form

Robin spends Monday morning on the six headings and a sources policy. In: vendor pricing pages, vendor status pages, state board rules Robin already knows, one trade journal. Out: Reddit as fact, Facebook group anecdotes as fact, "HIPAA compliant" badges without a BAA. Unchecked numbers are not facts. Monday afternoon Robin puts \$300 on a Tally form with five fields and a Stripe link. Monday night Robin writes three names.

Wednesday: three asks

Wednesday morning, Robin messages three clinic owners: "48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. One revision. Clock starts when I have the decision, the deadline, and payment."

One ignores. One says they might think about it in the fall. One replies. Decision: stay on the current scheduler or move to Tool B before October 1, because two front-desk people just gave notice. They already tried a vendor demo and a Facebook group thread. They pay \$300 Thursday at 9:12am. Intake is complete at 9:40. Clock ends Saturday 9:40am.

Thursday: sweep, then verify

Thursday, Robin uses a model to sweep: feature lists, pricing pages, two complaint patterns, HIPAA claims. That dump is ugly and stays private. Then Robin opens sources. Pricing is confirmed on both vendor pages, screenshots dated. A "HIPAA compliant" badge on Tool B's homepage is marketing copy; Robin cannot find a BAA sample without a sales call, so that goes in "do not know." A Reddit thread claiming Tool B lost appointments for a 200-provider group is one anonymous post — not a fact. Cut.

Robin almost makes the first real mistake of the job here. The model cites a 2025 uptime number with a neat URL. Robin pastes the URL, the page 404s, and the temptation is to leave the number in with "source: vendor." Robin deletes the number. "Do not know" gets a line: cannot verify Tool B's uptime for 2025 from a primary status page; vendor says "99.9 percent" on a marketing URL only. That delete is the product.

Friday: two pages, not seven

Robin writes two pages, not seven. Page one: the decision, the recommendation (stay through October, run a 14-day parallel on Tool B with one provider, do not cut over during staffing loss), the three verified differences that matter for a two-person front desk. Page two: sources, the "do not know" block, one thing Robin would not do (sign an annual on a sales call this week).

The "do not know" section, copied:

Cannot verify Tool B's uptime for 2025 from a primary status page; vendor says "99.9 percent" on a marketing URL only.

Cannot confirm BAA language without a sales call. If HIPAA is the reason to switch, that call is the next step, not a cutover.

No independent review of Tool B's SMS reminders in this state. Vendor blog only.

Saturday: delivery, then a revision that stays a revision

Saturday 8:10am, the PDF lands. Filename: "Scheduler-stay-or-move_brief_18Apr.pdf." Revision window until Monday 8:10. The owner asks one clarifying question: what "parallel" means in hours. Robin adds four sentences. Job closed. \$300. Time on the clock: about five hours of real work, two of them verification.

The owner also asks, in the same email, whether Robin can "just set up the parallel this week." Robin says no. That is a project. Robin offers to quote it as a different job or to leave the next step as written. The owner stays with the file. Robin does not work the weekend for free to seem helpful.

The first stranger sale

The clinic owner forwards page one to a partner at a second clinic. The partner emails Robin on the following Tuesday. Different scheduler, same staffing problem, deadline in September. Robin sends the same offer at \$300. They pay. Intake is complete Wednesday noon. Robin delivers Friday morning. No discount. That is the first stranger sale: \$300, on time, from a forward, not from a friend who wanted to be nice.

Robin notes the case, locks the fee at \$300, and does not write a twelve-page version "to be thorough." The sentence the first buyer used — "do not cut over during staffing loss" — becomes the next outbound line.

Copy you can actually send

Use these. Swap the topic. Do not add a biography. Do not add "AI-powered." The buyer already knows models exist. They are buying the check.

Post

I turned the way I already help [people] into a 48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, the next step. \$300. One revision. Clock starts when intake and payment are in. If you have a decision this month, the form is here: [link].

DM

You keep asking me what to do about [X]. I turned that into a fixed job: 48-hour brief, two pages, sources checked, a "do not know" section so we do not pretend. \$300, one revision. If you have a decision this month, I'll take one.

Page hero

A messy question in. A two-page brief out. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. 48 hours. \$300.

Checkout line

\$300. Two pages. 48 hours from complete intake and payment. One revision in the next 48 hours (clarify or correct, not a second question). Payment starts the job. Working days: [days].

Email 1, the ask

Subject: 48-hour brief on [X]

You keep asking me what to do about [X]. I made it a product so I stop rewriting the same email. 48-hour brief. Two pages. What I verified, what I still do not know, next step. \$300. One revision. If you have a decision with a date this month, reply with the decision, the deadline, and what you already tried. I'll send the payment link.

Email 2, intake complete

Subject: Clock starts [date/time]

Payment is in. Intake is complete. The 48 hours ends [date/time]. You will get a two-page file: decision, what I found, what I verified, what I do not know, next step, one thing I would not do. I will not send the working dump. One revision if you ask within 48 hours of delivery.

Email 3, delivery

Subject: Brief on [decision] — revision window until [date/time]

Attached: two-page brief on [decision]. I verified the items in section 3. Section 4 is what I still do not know — please do not treat those as facts. Recommended next step is on page one. One revision if you send it within 48 hours. After that, a new brief is a new order.

Refund email

Subject: Refund for [decision] brief

The file was [late / contained an unverified fact stated as fact]. I am refunding the \$300. You do not need to reply.

What you do not write

"AI knows everything." "Comprehensive report." "I'll keep looking until you are happy." "Let me hop on a call and we can see." Those sentences are how you work for free and ship fiction.

Week-by-week if you have a job

You can do this around a job if you protect two evenings and one weekend block. The goal of the first month is three on-time briefs, not a brand.

Week 1

Day 1: template plus sources policy plus \$300 form. Test the payment link. Write three names.

Day 2: three offers in the morning. If you have never written this shape, write a fake-name sample in the evening from a decision you already know. Do not take a second brief until the first has a home.

Day 3: follow one non-reply with a single line, not a new pitch. If a yes arrives, collect payment, then intake. Start no clock on a mushy email.

Day 4: if a brief is live, sweep and verify. If not, send two more asks from the same pile. Do not build a website.

Day 5: write and deliver if the clock demands it. If you have no buyer, stop adding features to the form. The form is fine. The asks are the work.

Day 6–7: deliver one on time, even if the first is \$150. Then lock the fee. Restate the revision window. Close the job. Do not spend Sunday inventing a retainer.

Week 2

Day 8: if the first buyer used a sentence, put that sentence in your next three asks. If they did not, ask what they needed that was missing — usually it is a clearer next step, not more pages.

Day 9: ship that as a template change, not as unpaid extra work. Tighten "recommended next step" so it is always a verb, an object, and a time.

Day 10–11: two more asks, or a second paid brief at full price. Same intake rules. Same clock.

Day 12–14: deliver the second on time or spend the weekend on verification, not on a new offer. Two on-time files beat a redesigned page.

Week 3

Take a third brief at full price or stop. Three on-time deliveries is enough proof. Do not add a monthly retainer. Speed and a spine in the "do not know" section are the goal.

If week 3 is empty, the problem is usually the ask list, not the template. Write five names who have a date in the next 30 days. Message those.

Week 4

If you have three on-time briefs: raise if the calendar is full, or stay at \$300 and take one more. Log fees, hours, on-time rate, sentence used. If you have fewer than two: pick a different path or go back to people who already ask you. Do not spend week 4 on ads.

The quality bar

A brief is good when a skeptical reader can see the seam between verified and guessed. Pretty language does not cover a fake citation. Length does not cover a missing next step.

Below the bar

A number you did not open, stated as fact.

A hallucinated URL, even once.

Empty "do not know," or "more research needed" with no object.

A recommendation that is a mood: "consider exploring options."

Twelve pages to look serious.

Clock missed, no written change.

Second question absorbed into the first fee.

Voice that sounds like a model: "In today's rapidly evolving landscape."

Sources you listed and did not open.

A file the buyer cannot forward without you explaining it.

Above the bar

Two pages. Six headings. Recommendation on page one.

Every verified number reopened at the source, dated if it can move.

"Do not know" you could defend to a hostile partner.

Next step a human can take this week without you.

One thing you would not do, named.

On time. Filename with topic and date.

Revision that clarifies, then closed.

Kitchen-table sentences.

Five tests before you hit send

The stranger test. A person who does not know the buyer can say the decision, the recommendation, and the biggest uncertainty in three minutes.

The open-the-link test. Every fact in section 3 has a source you opened in this job, not last year in your head.

The fake-number test. If the key number vanished, would the recommendation still stand? If not, the number belongs in "do not know" or the recommendation changes.

The verb test. The next step is a verb plus an object plus a time. "Stay on Tool A through October 1. Run a 14-day parallel." Not "look into options."

The clock test. The file is in their inbox inside the window you sold. If it is not, you do not send a draft and hope. You say you are late, you refund or you finish with their written OK, and you fix the process.

If you fail one test, you are not "basically done." You fix the file or you do not send it.

What to count

Count a short list. If you need a dashboard, you are avoiding the asks.

Week 1

Template exists: yes or no.

Sources policy written: yes or no.

Form live at \$300: yes or no.

Asks sent: target 3–5.

Paid briefs accepted: target 1.

On-time delivery: yes or no. This is the first-sale definition.

Ignore followers, impressions, and how clever the sweep sounded.

Day 30

Briefs delivered: target 3.

On-time rate: target 3/3. One late is a process bug. Two late means you sold a clock you do not keep.

Average fee. If you are still at \$150 after three, you are discounting as a personality trait.

Hours of real work per brief. Expect 4–8. If you are at 14, your niche is too wide or you are writing twelve pages.

Sources opened versus sources the model proposed. If you opened fewer than half, you are not verifying.

Whether they used the next step inside two weeks. A yes is a case. A no is a template problem or a bad-fit buyer.

Revision that tried to become a second question: count them. More than one per job means intake is soft.

Day 90

Briefs in the log: 6–10 is a real practice around a job. 1–2 means this stayed a hobby.

Stranger sales (not friends): at least 2.

Fee: \$300 or \$450, not \$150.

On-time rate at or above 80 percent.

One sentence from a buyer you reuse in outbound.

Zero retainers unless five briefs were on time and you named the pages.

If day 90 is empty, stop. Do not "rebrand the research desk." Go to a path with people who already pay you, or admit you will not send the asks.

Ignore

How clever the model sounded in the sweep. Page count past two. Time you spent choosing a font. Compliments that are not a used sentence.

One-line spreadsheet

Date | buyer type | decision in five words | fee | on time Y/N | hours | sentence they used | second question attempted Y/N

That is the whole system.

Objections you will hear — including your own

Reply once. Do not hold a seminar in the thread.

"Can't they just ask ChatGPT?"

They can. They will still have to check it. You are selling the check, the cut, and a next step they can defend in a meeting. If they want the paste, they should not hire you.

"Two pages feels thin for \$300."

Twelve pages they will not read is thinner. Price the decision, not the paper weight. Robin's clinic owner forwarded one page-one paragraph to a partner. That is use. If they want a literature review, that is a different product you probably should not sell.

"I might miss something."

You will. That is why "do not know" exists. Missing something and labeling it is professional. Missing something and stating it as fact is how this path dies. Your job is a defensible file on a date, not omniscience.

"They want me to just hop on a call."

A call without a brief becomes the whole job, unpaid. Offer the brief. If they want a 20-minute walkthrough after delivery, price it as \$75 or include once, in writing. Do not let the call replace the file.

"What if they want the whole project?"

Say no, or sell a different package. A brief that turns into implementation without a new quote is how you train them to ignore your scope. "I can quote that as a project. The brief stays \$300 and ends when the file lands."

"I do not have a niche."

Then you will be slow and worse. Start where you already know which sources lie. If you cannot name that place, skip this path. A generalist research shop is a fantasy that loses to a paste.

"\$300 is too high for four hours of work."

They are buying the turnaround, the cut, and the nerve to recommend. Do not add eight hours of padding to feel fair. That makes a worse file.

"What if they hate the recommendation?"

You refund late files and unverified facts stated as fact. You do not refund a recommendation they dislike. They bought judgment.

"Can you just keep looking until we know?"

No. The product is 48 hours and two pages. If they need more, they buy brief two on a tighter question.

"My industry is too specialized. Nobody will pay."

Specialized is the point. Generic "market research for founders" is where you compete with free. Stay narrow.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

Briefs sit next to other operator paths. They are not a funnel slide and they are not a bait-and-switch into a \$5,000 project they did not ask for. Recommend. Then wait to be asked.

What feeds a brief practice

People who already ask you for judgment: clients from a productized service, readers of a newsletter, buyers of a playbook who now have a live decision. A local business you already wrote posts for. A freelancer who already trusts your taste.

Cold traffic can work later. First sales come from three names you can text. If those three names do not exist, go do a path that creates them, then come back.

Your own last unpaid email thread is also feedstock. If you have already written the same "here is what I would do" message four times, that message is a brief wearing unpaid clothes.

What a brief feeds

A productized service, if the next step is work they want you to do. New quote. New scope. New number.

A playbook, if three briefs repeat the same structure. The template becomes a \$19–\$47 file with the client details stripped.

Custom project setups, if the recommendation is "configure the tool," not "I will configure it this afternoon for free."

Automation setups, if the next step is a named machine (form to draft, reminder, report). Quote path 19 separately.

Trust for a later retainer you still should not sell in week one.

What not to feed

Do not use a brief as a hook to upsell a project in the delivery email. The delivery email delivers. If they ask, you quote. If they do not ask, you log the sentence they used and you send the next outbound. Do not feed a public newsletter with their numbers unless they said yes in writing.

Mistakes that kill this path

Hallucinated citations. Briefs that refuse to recommend. Scope creep into doing the whole project. Those three still kill it. The rest kill it more slowly.

Ten mistakes and the recovery this week

Starting the clock on a vague email. Recovery: stop. Write "Clock has not started. I need the decision, the deadline, and what you already tried." Do not sweep until those exist.

Delivering twelve pages to look serious. Recovery: cut to two pages before you send. Move extra into your private dump. If it will not fit, it did not earn a sentence.

Leaving "do not know" empty because it felt like weakness. Recovery: add three specific holes before send. If you cannot name three, you have not verified.

Publishing the brief as a public post with the client's numbers in it. Recovery: take it down today. Apologize in writing. Do not wait to see if they noticed.

Claiming the model "knows everything." Recovery: delete that line from every page and DM. Replace with the offer sentence.

A second revision, then a third, because you did not close the window. Recovery: send "The revision window ended [date]. A new question is a new brief at \$300." Then stop typing.

Undercharging at \$49 so you feel like you can be sloppy. Recovery: next brief is \$300. You do not raise later "once you feel ready." You lock it now.

Pasting a URL you did not open into a footnotes list. Recovery: delete the line. Open the source or move the claim to "do not know." That reflex is the whole ethic.

Turning the recommendation into "I will come do it." Recovery: rewrite the next step so a human who is not you can take it. If they want you, quote a different path.

Taking a second brief before the first has landed. Recovery: finish the live one. A late first file poisons the second ask.

Using Facebook anecdotes as facts. Recovery: cut them. If a pattern matters, label it "unverified complaints in [place]" inside "do not know."

Weekend clocks you cannot staff. Recovery: put working days on the form today. Do not surprise them with Monday math after a Friday charge.

If you catch yourself in any of these, the recovery is this week, not "when things calm down." The path is small enough to fix on a Thursday night.

Tools — only what you need

The stack is boring on purpose. Three clients do not need a pipeline. They need you to open the links.

Exact stack

Google Docs or Word for the two-page file. Export PDF.

Tally or Google Form for intake. Five fields.

Stripe Payment Link at \$300.

The model you already pay for, used as a sweep. Not sent.

A browser. The actual source pages.

A folder of dated screenshots for numbers that might move.

A one-paragraph sources policy.

Email. Their inbox is the delivery system.

A simple sheet: the one-line log from the metrics section.

Setup order

Template Doc with six headings.

Sources policy paragraph.

Stripe link.

Form pointing at the link, price visible.

Test-buy from a second email.

Three names in a note.

Screenshot folder, empty, ready.

Then you send asks. Not before.

What not to buy

Do not buy a "research agent" stack, a scraping farm, a citation tool you do not understand, or a CRM. Do not buy a proposal platform. Do not buy a new domain to look like a firm. Do not add Notion if Docs already works.

The \$0 path

Docs, a Google Form, and a payment link you already have. The model you already use. Free email. The \$0 path is allowed for the first brief. It is not an excuse to skip the sources policy or the clock. If you have no payment tool, invoice and wait for the transfer before the clock.

Checklist

Two-page template with the six headings, including "do not know" and "one thing I would not do"

Sources policy written: in, out, unchecked numbers are not facts

Offer sentence on one page: 48 hours, two pages, \$300, one revision

Intake fields: decision, deadline, what they already tried

Working days stated if the clock does not run weekends

Payment before the clock

Clock starts only when intake is complete and payment is in

Test-buy of the form from a second email

Three names who already ask you "what should I do about X?"

Model for sweep, private dump, never sent

Every fact opened at the source

Dated screenshots for numbers that can move

Vendor claims labeled as vendor claims

Reddit and group anecdotes not used as facts

Recommendation is a verb, an object, and a time

"Do not know" has specific holes, not a mood

Filename has topic and date

Delivered inside 48 hours

Sweep dump not attached

Revision window restated in the email

Second question = second brief

After delivery: one sentence they used, written down

First discount, if any, is once. Then the fee is locked

One-line spreadsheet row filled

No implementation without a new quote

No public post with their numbers

Access to nothing of theirs except the documents they sent for this brief

Late file: refund or written clock change, no third path

FAQ

Why 48 hours and not a week?

A week becomes a research project. 48 hours forces a decision-sized file. If they need a week of interviews, that is not this product. Default: keep 48 hours on working days, written on the form.

What if intake arrives at 6pm Friday?

State your working days on the form. "48 hours on business days" is allowed if you write it before they pay. Do not surprise them with Monday math after a Friday charge unless the form said so. Default: write the days before the first dollar.

Do I show my working?

No. They get two pages. The sweep dump stays yours. Showing the raw model output trains them to skip you next time. Default: never attach the dump.

Can I use the brief as public content?

Not with their numbers, names, or quotes, unless they said yes in writing. You may rewrite a generic version weeks later if nothing identifying remains. Default: sample with fake names only.

What if I cannot verify the key number?

Put it in "do not know." Change the recommendation so it does not depend on a fake number. That section is why they trust you. Default: never promote an unverified number into a fact to make the file feel finished.

Is \$300 too high if I only spend four hours?

No. They are buying the turnaround, the cut, and the nerve to recommend. If four hours feels guilty, look at the value of the decision, not your typing speed. Default: \$300 until three on-time briefs say otherwise.

Should I offer unlimited email follow-up?

No. One revision. Then a new brief or a different path. Default: 48-hour revision window, clarify or correct only.

What if they want citations in academic form?

Give enough to reopen the source: title, publisher, date, URL. You are not submitting a journal article. You are making a decision defensible. Default: reopenable sources, not a style guide.

Can I do this without a niche?

You can try. You will be slower and worse. Start where you already know which sources lie. Default: one niche you can name in five words.

When do I raise the price?

After three on-time briefs at the current fee, if you are turning work away or the decisions are heavier. Not after one compliment. Default: \$300 to \$450, not a leap to \$2,000.

Do I need a website?

No. A form, a sentence, and three asks. Default: no site in week one.

What if they send a 40-page dump of files?

Name the three documents you will open. The rest is out. That is the \$450–\$600 version. Default: do not pretend you read forty pages in 48 hours.

Can I hire a researcher?

Not for month one. Default: you open the links.

What if the model invents a source that looks real?

You open it. If it 404s, you delete the claim. This will happen. Default: no citation you did not open.

Should I record a walkthrough of the brief?

Only as a \$75 extra, in writing. The product is the file. Default: file only.

What if I am late?

Tell them as soon as you know. Refund, or finish with their written OK on a new time. Default: refund a silent late.

Can this become my whole business?

Five to ten briefs a month around a job is a real number. Default: stack briefs, do not hire a desk.